

Developing Soft Skills and Personality



Professor T. Ravichandran

Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, IIT Kanpur

Week 3
Module 1
Lecture 13

Habits

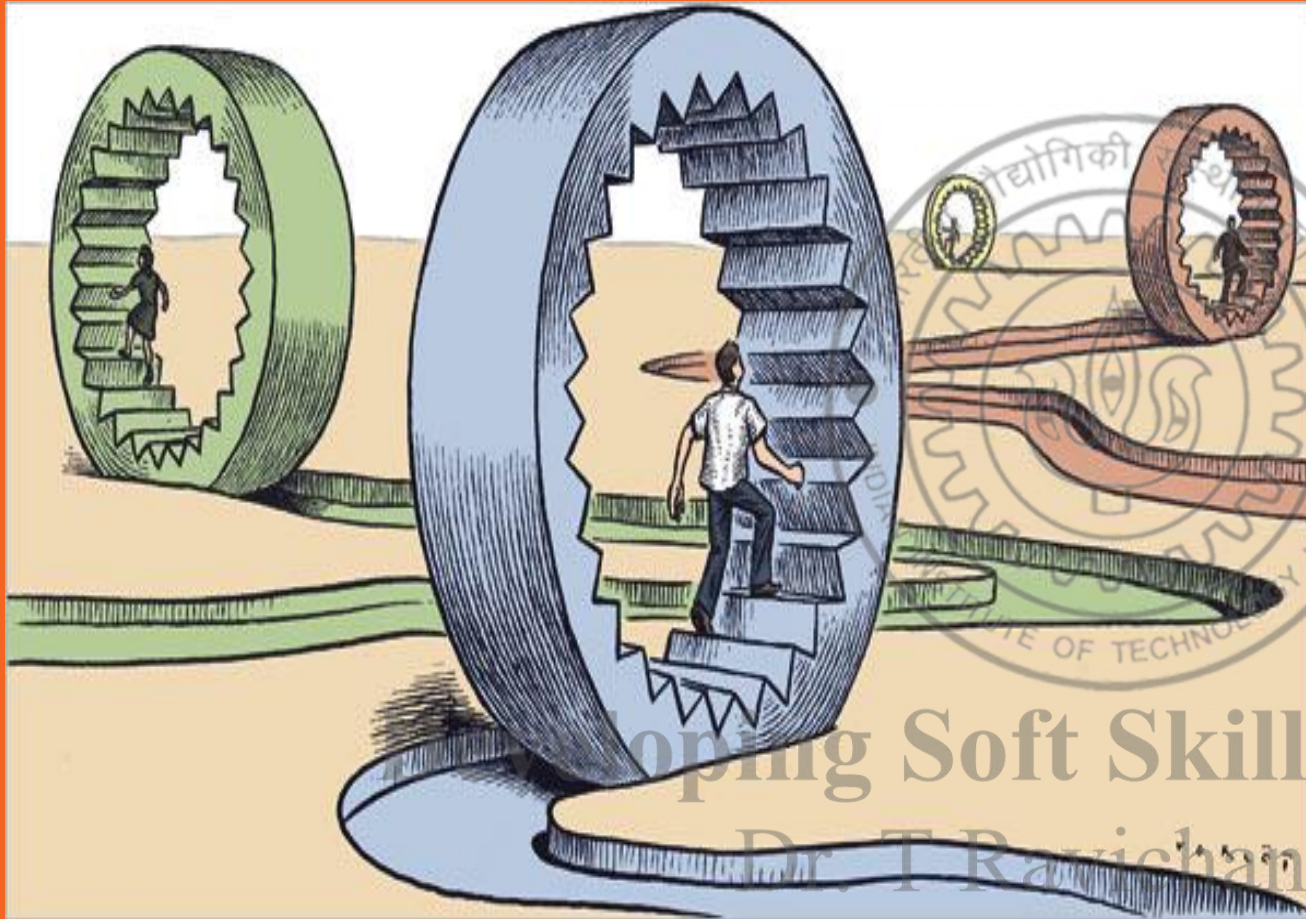
Guiding Principles

Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



- Why should you regulate stress?
- For strengthening yourself and remaining cheerful
- For completing jobs in time and create time for new jobs or just relax with family or friends.
- When you regulate, you govern, moderate, control and give direction to stress.
- Developing personal health habits, staying fit, eating in time, and sleeping well at night are important.
- Being mindful in whatever you do, and working with a plan and taking frequent breaks from your work.
- Concluded with some simple tips for quick relief from stress such as taking a cold or hot shower, talking to a friend, walking in a natural setting, listening to favourite/soothing music, deep breathing, watching a favourite movie, reading a favourite novel, or pages from motivating book, going to a temple, shopping in a mall, eating your favourite food and laughing.



HABITS

????



What does **habit** mean to you?

Habit-- Presumptions

- For most people, habit is something they do normally, spontaneously, regularly, without paying attention, without thinking or bothering about it . . .



- They think that they can form a habit as well as break it easily.

Presume that breaking can be done as and when they want it.

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Habits: Reality

Habits are behavioural responses to stimuli. Frequent repetitions can make these responses form behavioural patterns and function automatically.

It's easy to form bad habits

It's difficult to form good habits

It's difficult to break bad habits

They are easily formed, and they die hard!

How do you know what are good and bad habits?



Guiding Principles:

1. Bad habits do not need great efforts, will power and motivation either to form or maintain. (eating junk food)
2. Often you want to hide your bad habits from others. You feel embarrassed or guilty once someone knows about it. (addictions, stealing)
3. But . . . There's no way you can hide any bad habit in the long run. It shows on your health. Your body language reveals it.
(smoking, not sleeping at night)

Good habits are very difficult to form!



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Bad habits are very easy to form!



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Identifying Bad Habits

Story: Nails on the Wall



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4. Bad habits leave an indelible mark.



Bad Habits To Stop And Good Habits To Adopt



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Week 3
Module 2
Lecture 14

Habits

Identifying Good and Bad Habits

Highlights

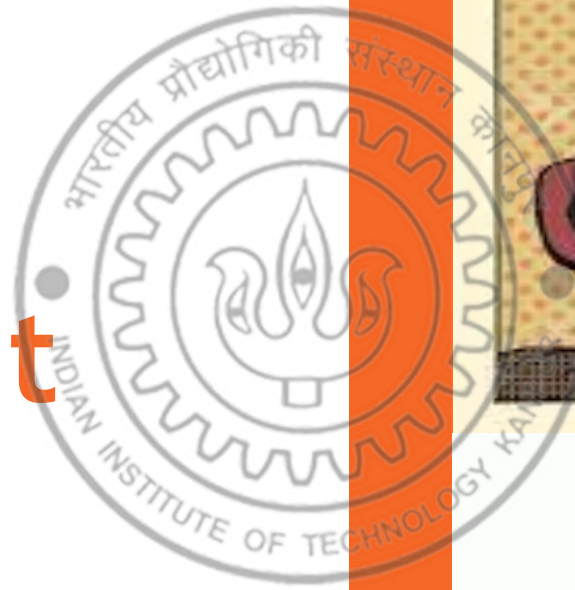
Highlights of the Last Lecture



- Habits and some presumptions associated with it
- Such as you can form and change them easily.
- Not all habits are easily formed; especially the good ones!
- Most of our habits are unconscious behavioural responses to external stimuli.
- Guiding principles to identify good and bad habits.
- Bad habits, even changed, will still leave an indelible mark on your character.
- Story of the nail on the wall.

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Story: The Patient

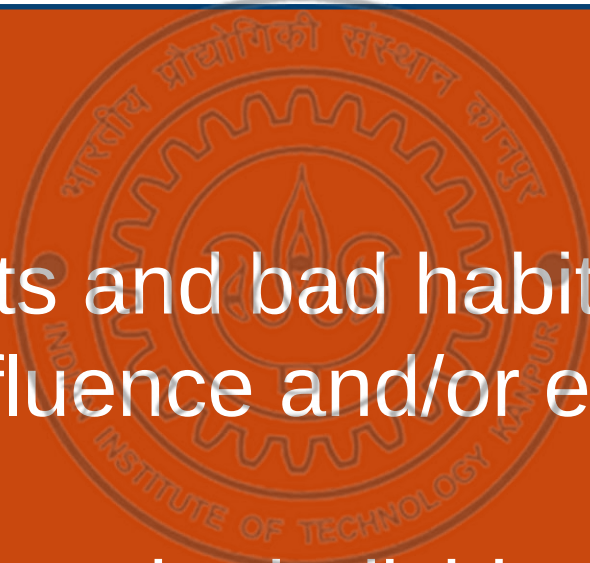


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The Lesson

5. Both good habits and bad habits are formed by peer group influence and/or environment.

But much depends on the individual perception and belief to retain a good habit or to change a bad habit.



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Guiding Principle: 6. Good/Bad Habit

Bad habits give immediate satisfaction/gratification but results in poor long term results.

Good habits do not give instant gratification but benefits with rich dividends in the long run.

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The Good, the Bad and the UGLY?

Bad

- Sleeping late night
- Delaying
- Disinterest in health and hygiene
- Gossiping, criticising others
- Any excessive, addictive habits (drinking, drugs)
- Whiles away time in watching TV, surfing the net
- Eats untimed, junk food
- Stealing things

Good

- Getting up early
- Doing it in time
- Maintaining fitness and keeping the surroundings clean
- Says only good things about others; develops self
- Enjoys things in moderation; avoids harmful ones
- Uses time discreetly
- Eats in time, healthy food
- Being honest and trustworthy

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Just Another Story!



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The Mother Who Loved Her Son So Much!

The Lesson: Nip it in the Bud!

7. Forming bad habits are dangerous and extremely harmful.

Therefore, it is better to nip a bad habit in the bud itself!

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*"First we make
our habits, then **our**
habits make us."*

— Charles C. Spurgeon



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Week 3
Module 3
Lecture 15

Habits

The Habit Cycle

Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



- The Doctor and the Patient
- Both good habits and bad habits are formed by peer group influence and/or environment.
- But much depends on the individual perception and belief to retain a good habit or to change a bad habit.
- The Mother Who Loved Her Son So Much!
- Forming bad habits are dangerous and extremely harmful.
- Therefore, it is better to nip a bad habit in the bud itself!

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Everything is habit . . .

Hard work is a habit; so is laziness/indolence

Perseverance is a habit; so is giving up

Success is a habit; so is failure

Excellence is a habit; so is mediocrity

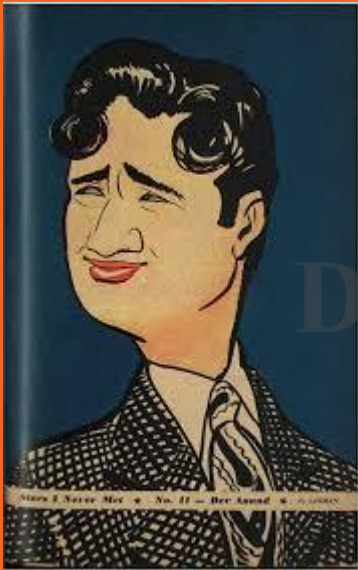
Choosing to form good habits is a habit; so is choosing to form bad habits!

Make the choice carefully!

The Habit Cycle



The decision to change . . .



R. K. Narayan's *The Guide*





You cannot change your future,
but you can change your habits,
and surely your habits will change your future.

- Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam

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We are what we repeatedly
do. Excellence, then, is not
an act, but a habit.
- Aristotle

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Week 3
Module 4
Lecture 16

Habits

Breaking Bad Habits

Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



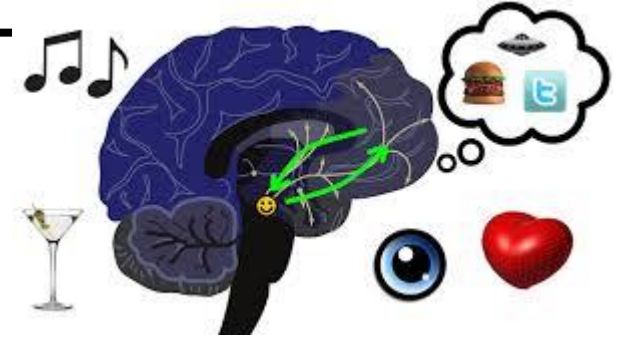
- Discussed about the importance of forming good habits because everything we do happens to be part of our habit formation. (Getting up in the bed to going back to it).
- Habit Cycle: Thoughts/Stimulus—Action/Reaction—Reward/Punishment—Habit formation—Character/Personality—Action/Reaction—Success/Failure
- The Decision to Change: Raju's decision (in R. K. Narayan's *Guide*) to change from a sinner to a martyr and saint.
- The Lessons:
 - Circumstance do not make a man; it reveals him.
 - Writers like William Golding asserts that "The Beast is within us." But R. K. Narayan implies that "The God is also within us."
 - Conclusion: The ability to form bad habits as well as good habits lies within us.

Why is that some are able to
change their habits in a
lightning second and others
are not able to do in ages?

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The answer lies in . . .



Their level of self-awareness; knowing what is really good and bad for them.

Perceiving correctly that a bad habit is really harmful despite its short gains or rewards.

Most of the rewards are linked with Dopamine.

Dopamine is a neurotransmitter of human brain that is linked with motivation and reward. It is a chemical that induces pleasure. It gets released every time you feel joyful about something you have done—good or bad!

The answer lies in . . . Dopamine!

It plays a crucial role in forming addictive habits. Certain drugs stimulate its production, leading to high levels of activity causing ecstasy. Since its leaving causes depression or slowing down of energy, the brain quickly learns to seek out drugs that will stimulate production, leading to addiction.

While Dopamine seeks those activities that gives you pleasure, it also motivates you to avoid unpleasant experiences.

Thus, bad habits are usually formed in those circumstances where it is easy to seek pleasure by which you are also able to avoid painful or disagreeable experiences—at least for that time being!



Countering Dopamine



It's difficult but not impossible . . .

Accepting that sad and depressive times are part of our lives. There are normal and are required to experience the happiness of best times.

Agony if it precedes, intensifies the experience of ecstasy that comes later.

Auto telling our brain that it's okay to be unhappy because you want to experience happiness.

Reinforcing in the mind that you will stay calm and cool despite testing moments.

Visualizing a fulfilling and meaningful life for the future.



Unhappiness out of emotional break-ups

The Zeigarnik Effect: Bluma Zeigarnik (1900–1988), the Russian psychologist, first described the Zeigarnik effect in her 1927 doctoral thesis.

Psychwiki.com: The Zeigarnik Effect is the tendency to experience intrusive thoughts about an objective that was once pursued and left incomplete. The automatic system signals the conscious mind, which may be focused on new goals, that a previous activity was left incomplete. It seems to be human nature to finish what we start and, if it is not finished, we experience dissonance.

(http://www.psychwiki.com/wiki/Zeigarnik_Effect)



Unhappiness out of emotional break-ups

***The Zeigarnik Effect* highlights a compulsive Need to Complete.**

Need to complete a task once it has been initiated.

Incompletion of it leads to intrusive thoughts in the brain, which can stop only when the person returns to complete the task.

Uncompleted tasks will stay on your mind until you finish them!

That's the reason why emotional break-ups are causes for long-time unhappiness!

Dealing with Emotional Break-Ups: The Dopamine Way!

Mind treats an emotional break-up as an uncompleted task as so many activities were planned with a particular partner till the end of one's life and career.

That's the reason why it's difficult for many to come out of emotional break-ups!

But the only solution is to give it a symbolic completion: literally burning or burying any remnants (photos, letters, messages, etc.). The brain needs to register this message of completion to move forward uninterruptedly and peacefully.

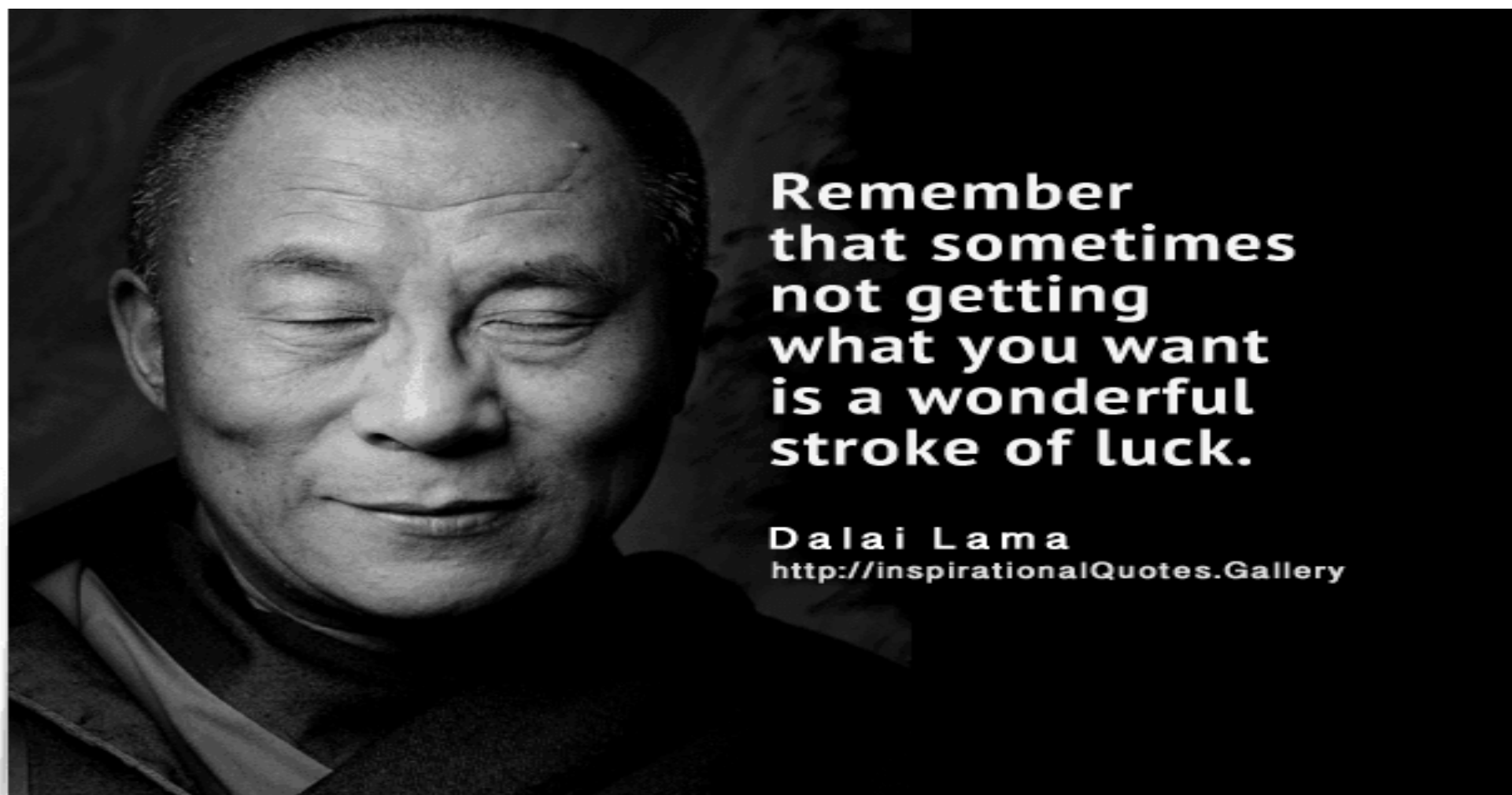
Dealing with Emotional Break-Ups: The Dopamine Way!

Revisiting the places where one used to frequent together will only result in Dopamine-craving and subsequent alienation.

It is important to start a different routing with a different goal, for instance, keeping fit or trying creative writing. This will release a new set of Dopamine every time a goal is achieved.

Reminding of the bad things the other person did for you will help minimise the dopamine craving for the lost idyllic times and euphoric moments!

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**Remember
that sometimes
not getting
what you want
is a wonderful
stroke of luck.**

Dalai Lama

<http://inspirationalQuotes.Gallery>

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Week 3
Module 5
Lecture 17

Habits

Zeigarnik Effect for Productivity

Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Why is that some are able to change their habits in a lightning second and others are not able to do in ages?

The answer lies in . . .

Their level of self-awareness; correct perceptions of reality, and using Dopamine in a constructive manner.

It plays a crucial role in forming addictive habits.

Bad habits are usually formed in those circumstances where it is easy to seek pleasure by which you are also able to avoid painful or disagreeable experiences—at least for that time being!

The Zeigarnik Effect highlights a compulsive Need to Complete.

Emotional break-ups leave lots of incomplete tasks, hence, the dissonance.

New goals: keeping fit or trying creative writing. This will release a new set of Dopamine every time a goal is achieved.

Reminding of the bad things the other person did for you will help minimise the dopamine craving for the lost idyllic times and euphoric moments!



Using the Zeigarnik Effect for productivity and personal growth.

Since unfinished activity gives anxiety, it is important to focus on an activity and stick to it till its completion.

If you start it, finish it. Don't leave it in between. This is an important growth habit you need to inculcate in your personality!

Because finishing it gives you a sense of completion, utmost satisfaction, and blissfulness and peace of mind.

When move from one finished task to another, your confidence level will increase and you will be devoid of any anxiety.

This knowledge also helps in beating procrastination: you realize that it is just the starting trouble, once you start somehow, you will finish it anyhow!

Using the Zeigarnik Effect for productivity and personal growth

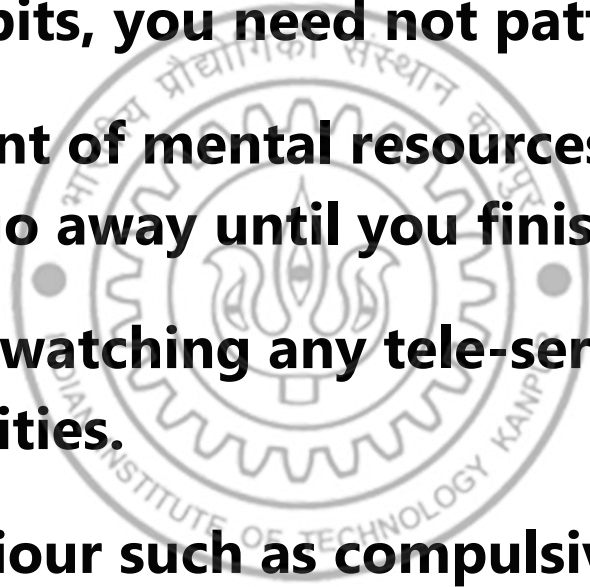
Brain needs to complete the cycle of an activity that we have started. So if you want to free the brain from addictive habits, you need not pattern any uncompleted task in it.

Unfinished tasks use large amount of mental resources by occupying and blocking premium space but refusing to go away until you finish it.

For this reason, you should stop watching any tele-serials if you want to free your mind from a chain of incomplete activities.

The brain forms addictive behaviour such as compulsive TV serial watching till it receives the information that the whodunit is known and that the serial will not be continued anymore in the next week or the week after!

Same thing happens while playing video games; they take you to a near level of closure but never let you reach it, by making you stick to it and get addicted perennially.



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Using the Zeigarnik Effect for productivity and personal growth

Used constructively, ZE can give you the motivation to make you leave from sick bed and complete the task at hand (as great artists have always done).

Simple example: ear worms: songs that stick to your mind till you completely sing it or hear it!

Brain is immersed in something that does not let you focus on task at hand.

Internalisation of the Zeigarnik Effect can give you the much needed intrinsic motivation to achieve or excel in any activity.

You can rewire your brain to seek completions, as it takes you to resolution of tension and adds to the feel-good factor.



*This above all, to thine ownself be true,
And it must follow, as the night the day,
Thou canst not then be false to any man.*

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-Shakespeare

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Week 3
Module 5
Lecture 17

Habits

Zeigarnik Effect for Productivity

Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



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Using the Zeigarnik Effect for productivity and personal growth

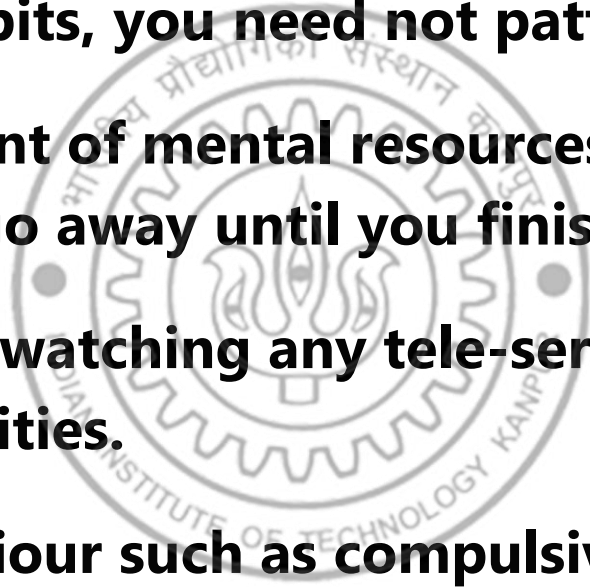
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Unfinished tasks use large amount of mental resources by occupying and blocking premium space but refusing to go away until you finish it.

For this reason, you should stop watching any tele-serials if you want to free your mind from a chain of incomplete activities.

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Same thing happens while playing video games; they take you to a near level of closure but never let you reach it, by making you stick to it and get addicted perennially.



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Using the Zeigarnik Effect for productivity and personal growth

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You can rewire your brain to seek completions, as it takes you to resolution of tension and adds to the feel-good factor.



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And it must follow, as the night the day,
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-Shakespeare

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Week 3
Module 6
Lecture 18

Habits

Forming Success Habits

Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Using the Zeigarnik Effect for productivity and personal growth. Since unfinished activity gives anxiety, it is important to focus on an activity and stick to it till its completion.

If you start it, finish it. Don't leave it in between. This is an important growth habit you need to inculcate in your personality!

This knowledge also helps in beating procrastination: you realize that it is just the starting trouble, once you start somehow, you will finish it anyhow!

Unfinished tasks use large amount of mental resources by occupying and blocking premium space but refusing to go away until you finish it. That's why you should stop watching television-serials or any serialised programme.

Video games use the same principle to give addiction to its players. Internalisation of the Zeigarnik Effect can give you the much needed intrinsic motivation to achieve or excel in any activity. You can rewire your brain to seek completions, as it takes you to resolution of tension and adds to the feel-good factor.

Breaking Bad Habits

- Process involves a rewiring of the brain and reconfiguring the habit-chain loop. Brain does not know how to differentiate the good from the bad habit.
- Stop the way you started it—in tiny bits.
- Alcoholic addiction starts with the first sip that was repulsive to taste and body.
- Similarly, your first attempt in changing a bad habit has to start in a tiny bit and then gradually increase.
- The frequency of use has to reduce.
- Bad habits generally don't disappear for ever. So are good habits. It's like the hidden six-pack beneath a fat tommy!

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Breaking Bad Habits

- Replacing a bad habit with a good habit
- Reinforcing the good habit in testing times.
- You procrastinate when you are overwhelmed to see a big task. As the saying goes, "You eat an elephant, bit by bit." Divide huge tasks into manageable chunks. Brain releases dopamine every time you complete a part and energises you to take the next part.
- Energy level sinks when you can't see the finish line. Adrenaline pumps in when you can see it!
- Most bad habits are formed because of a negative emotional state such as boredom, frustration or depression. So counter lethargy by activity. Keep yourself busy and overloaded in various aspects of your life and career.

Developing Good Habits

- You need develop good habits by keep one more Guiding Principle in mind: KEEP YOUR BRIAN LIGHT AND FREE
- To keep your brain light and free, you need to shed lot of excess fatty content that it might have developed from bad habits.
- Hence, practice good habits that will free your brain and mind such as:
 1. Not leaving any task uncompleted. Any task left unattended will keep interrupting you till you get back to it and finish it.
 2. If you refuse to finish it, it will hang heavy in your brain causing you less space for focussing and concentrating on new activities.
 3. Reading a serialised novel, or watching a tele-serial is likely to wire you into the habit of becoming serial-addicts.

Good Habits and Success

- Go hand in hand
- Good habits determine your level of efficiency and gain you lots of love and respect from your boss and colleagues.
- They make you indispensable and irreplaceable, which would give you the ultimate sense of job security and satisfaction.
- Some habits of highly successful people worth inculcating in you:
 - 1. Be extremely hard working
 - 2. Do the extra work with a smile, even if you don't get paid.
 - 3. Never look at your watch and work.

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Good Habits and Success

- 4. Work till you complete, so that your mind stays calm and you can sleep peacefully each night.
- 5. Focus on the most important goal
- 6. Never spend more time on something that can be completely avoided!
- 7. Concentrate 100%, you will finish it faster than the rest!

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You can live a life that truly works and you can achieve peak performance in all areas of your life.

You can not only survive life's unexpected changes and transitions but also thrive.

Powerful change is possible.

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You are fully capable of creating a life that you choose.

Shelley Stile, "Conscious Living - The Key To Positive And Lasting Change."

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